

card numbers, email addresses and passwords. This has made them a target for hackers. Defaced websites can also be used to spread propaganda like radical religious or political ideologies.

This article aims to introduce you to hacking techniques targeted at web servers and ways to counter them.

Webserver vulnerabilities

A web server has both hardware and software components. Hackers target the software component to gain unauthorized entry to the web server. Here are some of the common vulnerabilities that hackers exploit

- **Default settings**

Default settings leave the server open to most tricks employed by the hackers. These settings, which might include the default username and password, can be easily guessed by hackers. Default settings might also allow dangerous scripts stitched by hackers to run on the server without authorization.

- **Misconfiguration**

Specific configurations of operating systems and networks such as allowing users to execute commands on the server can be dangerous. As mentioned earlier, if the user does not have good password hackers can run malicious scripts on the server.

- **Bugs in the operating system and web servers**

Bugs discovered in the operating system or web server's software can be used to gain access to the system without authorization.

- **Lack of security policy and procedures**

Lack of basic security policy and procedures such as regularly updating the antivirus software or patching the operating system and web server software can create major security loopholes for hackers to exploit.

Types of Web Servers

Before we get into the warzone, we need to know the enemy. Common web servers are listed below:

- **Apache**– A commonly used web server on the internet (it is an open-source software). 24% of all web servers employ Apache HTTP Server. Most PHP websites run on this type of web server.